

Travel and Expense Policy

Policy code: POL-FIN-007 | Owner: Group Finance | Effective date: 1 April 2025 | Version: 2

This version supersedes version 1 dated 1 April 2024. Claims for expenses incurred on or after 1 April 2025 are assessed under this version.

Summary of changes

- Approval thresholds raised: line managers approve claims up to £750 and budget holders up to £3,000; claims above £3,000 go to the CFO, following the removal of the Finance Director role.
- Per-diem and hotel caps updated for all cities, and Munich added.
- Claim deadline shortened from 90 days to 60 days.
- Itemised receipts now required for every item over £5.
- First class rail now permitted only for journeys over 4 hours.
- Economy class now applies to flights under 8 hours.
- Client entertainment, team meal and working-late meal limits increased.
- International Travel Pre-Approval (F-221) must now be submitted 14 days before travel.
- Mileage rates for the Netherlands, United States and Malaysia updated.

1. Purpose

This policy sets out how Meridian Instruments Ltd employees travel on company business and how they are reimbursed for reasonable expenses incurred while doing their job. It applies to all employees, contractors engaged through Meridian payroll and temporary staff at every Meridian site: Leeds, Rotterdam, Austin and Penang.

The principle behind the policy is simple. Spend Meridian's money as carefully as you would spend your own. Choose the most economical option that still allows you to do your work safely and effectively, and never make or receive a claim that you would not be comfortable explaining to a colleague in Finance.

2. Scope

This policy covers business travel (air, rail, road, taxis and hire cars), hotel accommodation, meals and daily subsistence, client entertainment, and other out-of-pocket business costs such as professional subscriptions and small purchases.

It does not cover the purchase of goods or services from suppliers, which must be raised as a purchase requisition under the Procurement Manual (POL-FIN-012) and approved in line with the Delegation of Authority and Approval Matrix (POL-FIN-003). Use of the Northgate Commercial Card is governed by the Corporate Card Policy (POL-FIN-009).

3. Before you travel

All travel must have a clear business purpose and be agreed in advance with your line manager. Consider whether a video call on Teams would achieve the same result before booking a trip. Where several colleagues are attending the same event, coordinate so that the number of travellers is kept to the minimum needed.

International travel requires a completed International Travel Pre-Approval form (F-221). The form must be submitted at least 14 days before the planned departure date and approved by your budget holder. The form records the purpose of the trip, the estimated total cost and the cost centre to be charged. Travel booked without an approved F-221 may not be reimbursed. Urgent customer site visits that cannot meet the 14-day lead time may be approved by the budget holder

with a written reason attached to the F-221.

Book flights, rail and hotels through the Travel module in Atlas, which connects to our travel management company. Step-by-step instructions, including how out-of-policy bookings are handled, are in the Travel Booking Guide. Bookings made outside Atlas are only reimbursed when the Atlas option was unavailable or demonstrably more expensive, and the reason must be stated on the claim.

4. Air travel

Class of travel is determined by the scheduled flight time of each individual flight, not the total journey time.

- Flights under 8 hours: economy class.
- Flights of 8 hours or more: premium economy class may be booked.
- Flights over 10 hours: business class may be booked with prior approval from the CFO.

Book at least 14 days ahead where possible and choose the lowest logical fare. Seat selection and one checked bag are reimbursable. Airline lounge memberships are not. Where a flight lands before 07:00 local time after an overnight journey, a day-room at the destination hotel may be claimed within the hotel cap.

5. Rail travel

Standard class is the default for all rail travel. First class may be booked where the scheduled journey time exceeds 4 hours, or where an advance first class ticket is cheaper than the flexible standard fare. Railcards purchased for frequent business travel are reimbursable where they pay for themselves within the year. Leeds to London journeys are standard class unless an advance first class fare is cheaper.

6. Road travel and mileage

Use of a private car for business travel is reimbursed per unit of distance at the rates below. Commuting between home and your normal place of work is not business mileage. Mileage must be recorded on a Mileage Log (F-207) or entered in the mileage section of the Atlas claim, showing date, start point, destination, purpose and distance.

Country | Rate

UK | 45p per mile, first 10,000 miles

UK | 25p per mile, above 10,000 miles

Netherlands | €0.23 per km

United States | \$0.70 per mile

Malaysia | RM 0.90 per km

Employees who receive a car allowance or a company car under the Company Car and Car Allowance Policy (POL-FIN-015) must follow that policy for business mileage; the rates above do not apply to them.

Hire cars should be compact or intermediate class and booked through Atlas. Refuel before returning the vehicle. Electric hire cars are preferred where charging is practical. Taxis and ride-hailing services are reimbursed where no reasonable public transport option exists, when carrying heavy equipment such as Tessera demonstration kits, or when travelling after 21:00.

7. Accommodation

Hotels should be booked through Atlas at or below the nightly cap for the city. Caps are per room per night and include breakfast where offered, but exclude local tourist taxes. Where a

trade fair or major event means no room is available at the cap, the budget holder may approve a higher rate in advance through the out-of-policy workflow in Atlas.

Staying with friends or family instead of a hotel does not attract an accommodation payment, but the per-diem still applies.

8. Per-diem and hotel caps by city

The per-diem allowance covers meals and incidental expenses for a full day away from your home location with an overnight stay. On travel days where you depart after 12:00 or return before 12:00, half the per-diem applies. The per-diem is a cap on reimbursed actual spend supported by receipts, not a flat payment.

City | Per diem (meals) | Hotel cap per night

London | £65 | £210

Leeds | £45 | £120

Rotterdam | €55 | €165

Amsterdam | €70 | €210

Frankfurt | €65 | €185

Munich | €70 | €190

Austin | \$70 | \$230

New York | \$95 | \$350

Penang | RM 170 | RM 420

Kuala Lumpur | RM 200 | RM 480

Singapore | SGD 100 | SGD 350

For cities not listed, use the rate for the nearest listed city in the same country, or ask expenses@meridian-instruments.example for guidance. Where a conference fee includes meals, the per-diem is reduced by the value of the meals provided.

9. Expense category limits

Category | Limit

Team meal (manager-approved) | £30 per head

Working-late meal (after 20:00) | £20 per person

Client entertainment | £75 per head

Professional subscriptions | £300 per year

Business books and publications | £100 per year

Hotel laundry (trips over 5 nights) | £20 per trip

Mobile roaming add-ons | actual cost, pre-agreed

Limits for EUR, USD and MYR claims are converted at the Group budget exchange rate for the financial year. Alcohol is only reimbursable as part of client entertainment and must be moderate. Client entertainment must be recorded with the names and organisations of all attendees. Gifts and hospitality given to or received from third parties must also be recorded where required by the Code of Conduct (POL-CORP-001). Spend above the client entertainment limit is not reimbursed unless approved in advance by the budget holder.

Professional subscriptions must relate to your current role, for example membership of an engineering institution or a chartered finance body. Subscriptions above £300 in a year, and any course or training fee, are handled under the Learning and Development Policy (POL-HR-035) rather than through expenses.

10. Non-reimbursable items

- Fines, parking penalties and speeding tickets.
- Personal travel insurance (Meridian provides business travel cover).

- In-room films, minibar and spa charges.
- Upgrades bought with personal funds or loyalty points exchanged for cash.
- Expenses for partners or family members.
- Clothing and personal grooming.
- Tips above 15% of the bill, except where local custom in the United States requires a standard gratuity.

11. Submitting a claim

Claims are submitted in Atlas under Atlas > Expenses > New Claim. Each claim must show the cost centre, the business purpose and, for meals and entertainment, the names of the people present.

An itemised receipt is required for every item over £5 (or local equivalent). Photographs of receipts uploaded to Atlas are acceptable; keep the originals until the claim is paid. Card statements and payment-terminal slips are not a substitute for an itemised receipt.

Claims must be submitted within 60 days of the date the expense was incurred. Claims older than 60 days will be rejected unless the Group Financial Controller agrees an exception in writing.

Reimbursement is paid through payroll. The cut-off dates for each site are published in the payroll calendars, and an approved claim that misses a cut-off is paid in the following pay run.

12. Approval thresholds

Each claim is routed for approval in Atlas according to its total value.

Claim total | Approver

Up to £750 | Line manager

£750.01 to £3,000 | Budget holder

Above £3,000 | CFO

No one may approve their own claim or a claim from someone to whom they report. Claims from members of the Executive team are approved by the CFO; claims from the CFO are approved by the CEO. Approvers should reject claims that lack receipts, a business purpose or attendee names rather than approving them with a comment.

13. Compliance

Finance audits a sample of claims every month. Claims that breach this policy will be returned or reduced. Deliberately false or inflated claims are treated as gross misconduct under the Disciplinary and Grievance Procedure (POL-HR-040).

Questions about this policy should be sent to expenses@meridian-instruments.example.